

Production probability, transport, and grammatical possibility

Reanalysing the English dative alternation with open data

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Abstract

This draft develops a no-new-data reassessment of Bresnan et al. (2007). The current analyses reproduce the production-choice target from `languageR::dative`, add explicit null and partial-pooling checks, and test whether the resulting conditioning profile transports to the Spoken BNC2014 dative dataset. The working result is that modern modelling preserves the classic production conclusion, while BNC2014 provides positive but partial cross-corpus transport evidence. The manuscript uses that result to keep apart production probability, acceptability preference, and grammatical possibility.

Keywords: dative alternation; probabilistic grammar; grammaticality; corpus linguistics; acceptability

1 THE PROBLEM

TODO: Open from the distinction the project needs: a construction can be rare, lexically restricted, strongly dispreferred, register-bound, or contrary to a linguist's informal judgment without thereby falling outside the grammar. The dative alternation is useful because the choice between the double-object and prepositional patterns has both a long theoretical history and a reusable probabilistic dataset.

2 THE ORIGINAL TARGET

TODO: Present Bresnan et al. (2007) as the conceptual and empirical anchor: probabilistic corpus modelling as evidence about grammatical possibility, not as a replacement for grammar. Keep the level distinction explicit: corpus evidence is being used to test claims about a production profile, not to reduce grammar to frequency.

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3 DATA AND DIRECT REPLICATION

This section will report the verified `languageR::dative` data path and the direct production-choice target. The initial inspection confirms 3,263 rows, 15 columns, and the NP/PP outcome used for the first reproducible reanalysis. The baseline analysis should be presented as a disciplined reproduction step, not as the paper's final contribution.

4 MODERN MODELLING UPDATE

This section will report the baseline, null, and partial-pooling results. The important finding is conservative: the hierarchical verb-intercept model essentially matches the fixed-verb model and preserves Bresnan et al.'s production-choice conclusion. Modern modelling changes the statistical packaging more than the linguistic conclusion.

5 GENERALIZATION AND ACCEPTABILITY

This section will report the BNC2014 harmonization and transport result. The first transport model shows that a spoken six-verb `languageR` model predicts BNC2014 well above a marginal baseline, but remains weaker than a BNC-native model. If acceptability resources enter later, they should mark a level shift: production probability and acceptability preference are related evidence streams, not the same measurement.

6 GRAMMATICAL POSSIBILITY

TODO: Connect the empirical result back to the broader **(Un)grammatical** program. The payoff should be a sharper vocabulary for saying that an alternation is grammatical but conditioned, possible but dispreferred, or outside the projection profile supported by the evidence.

7 CONCLUSION

TODO: Conclude with the methodological lesson, not the dataset. The project should show how a classic corpus-probabilistic result can be made reproducible, portable, and conceptually useful for the ontology of grammatical possibility.

DATA AND CODE AVAILABILITY

The analysis scripts fetch public datasets to temporary locations and do not commit raw corpus data. Derived summaries, diagnostics, and model outputs are stored under `data/derived/`. Source, licence, and dataset-verification notes are tracked in `notes/source-verification.md`.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

TODO: Add final AI-use disclosure with the actual model list used on the project.

REFERENCES

- Bresnan, J., Cueni, A., Nikitina, T., & Baayen, R. H. (2007). Predicting the dative alternation. In G. Bouma, I. Krämer & J. Zwarts (Eds.), *Cognitive foundations of interpretation* (pp. 69–94). Royal Netherlands Academy of Arts; Sciences.